TWELVE-MONTH OUTLOOK

Gold Outlook: Twelve-Month Prospects

Constructive on a drift-grade regime: base case $4,259/oz at six months and $4,448/oz at twelve, the upside tail several times the downside.

ZION / ZION_CHAIN research desk · Analyst: Shaun · Data as of 26 October 2026 · Next scheduled update: 1 November 2026 (monthly issue)

RATING	SPOT (COMEX, 26 OCT)	6-MONTH BASE CASE	12-MONTH BASE CASE	P(HIGHER) 6M / 12M
Constructive / Overweight	**$4,035**	**$4,259** $3,948 to $4,613	**$4,448** $4,051 to $5,158	**70% / 76%**

Executive summary

View: Constructive (Overweight), drift-grade conviction. Our base case puts gold at $4,259/oz in six months and $4,448/oz in twelve, from a COMEX front-month close of $4,035 on 26 October 2026. The probability of a higher price rises with horizon, from 56% at one month to 76% at twelve, against an unconditional 52% to 62% for all months since 1990. The distribution is right-skewed: at twelve months the 90th-percentile gain (about $1,810 above spot, to $5,840) is several times the 10th-percentile loss (about $300 below, to $3,733).

The view rests on three legs. First, the ZION recursive cell that owns the current regime (Industrial Production relative to CPI, 12-month window, type 14) has been right on 82% of 91 prior calls, every one of them UP; it is a bull-regime detector, not a timing model, and we present it as such. Second, the physical market is tight where it matters: Shanghai trades $18/oz over London (91st percentile since 2003), India has flipped from discount to a $5/oz premium, and central banks absorbed 289 t in Q2, 62% more than a year earlier. Third, the macro gate is mixed rather than hostile: 10-year yields have risen 87 bp in six months to 5.19% and the dollar is firmer, which explains the 17% correction from the spring high, but real yields at 1.1% and CPI at 4.1% keep the carry cost of gold modest.

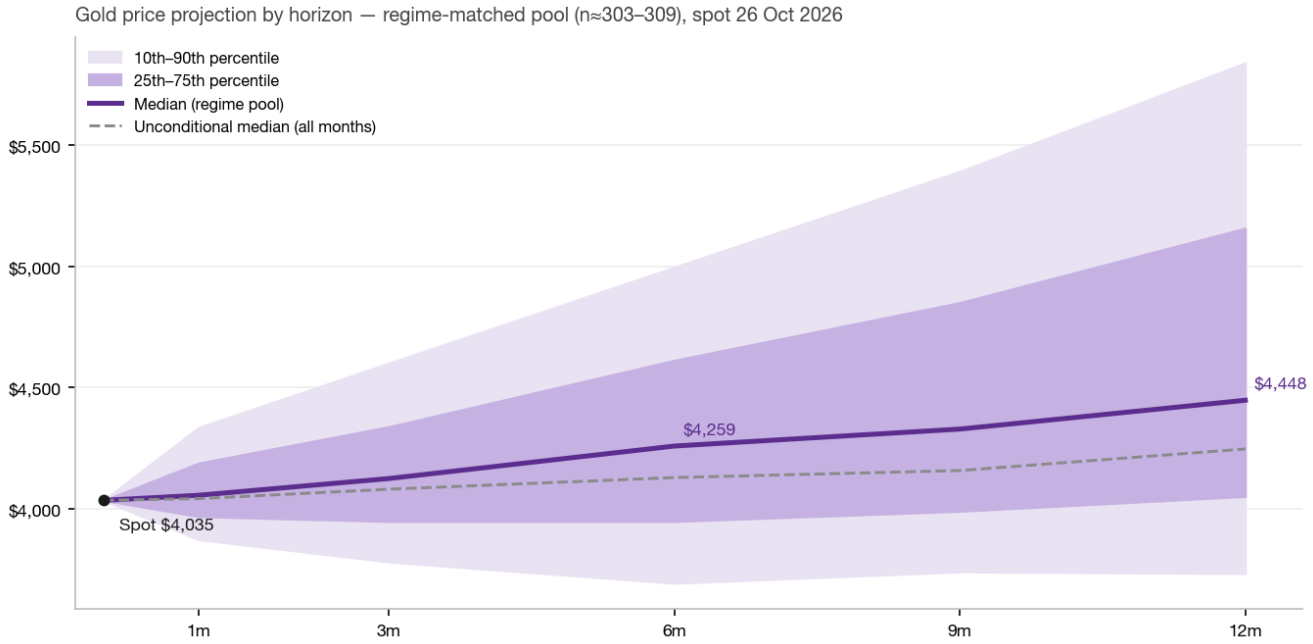
The principal risks are a crowded long (speculative net length is 53% of open interest, the 99th percentile since 1986), the collapse in jewellery demand (down 19% over twelve months to 1,501 t, the weakest since the series began in 2010), and a further leg higher in yields. We would add on weakness toward the 25th-percentile band ($3,950 to $3,990 over one to six months) rather than chase strength.

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Horizon	Base case (median)	25th to 75th percentile	10th to 90th percentile	P(higher)	Unconditional P(higher)
1 month (Nov 2026)	$4,056	$3,968 to $4,189	$3,873 to $4,336	56%	52%
3 months (Jan 2027)	$4,125	$3,948 to $4,339	$3,781 to $4,601	62%	56%
6 months (Apr 2027)	$4,259	$3,948 to $4,613	$3,693 to $4,997	70%	60%
9 months (Jul 2027)	$4,329	$3,990 to $4,851	$3,740 to $5,392	73%	62%
12 months (Oct 2027)	$4,448	$4,051 to $5,158	$3,733 to $5,840	76%	62%

All five horizons are drawn from one pool of 303 to 309 historical months that share the current regime type, so the ranges widen coherently with time and the medians are monotone. Prices are ranges, never points, by house rule.

Price projections: 1, 3, 6, 9 and 12 months



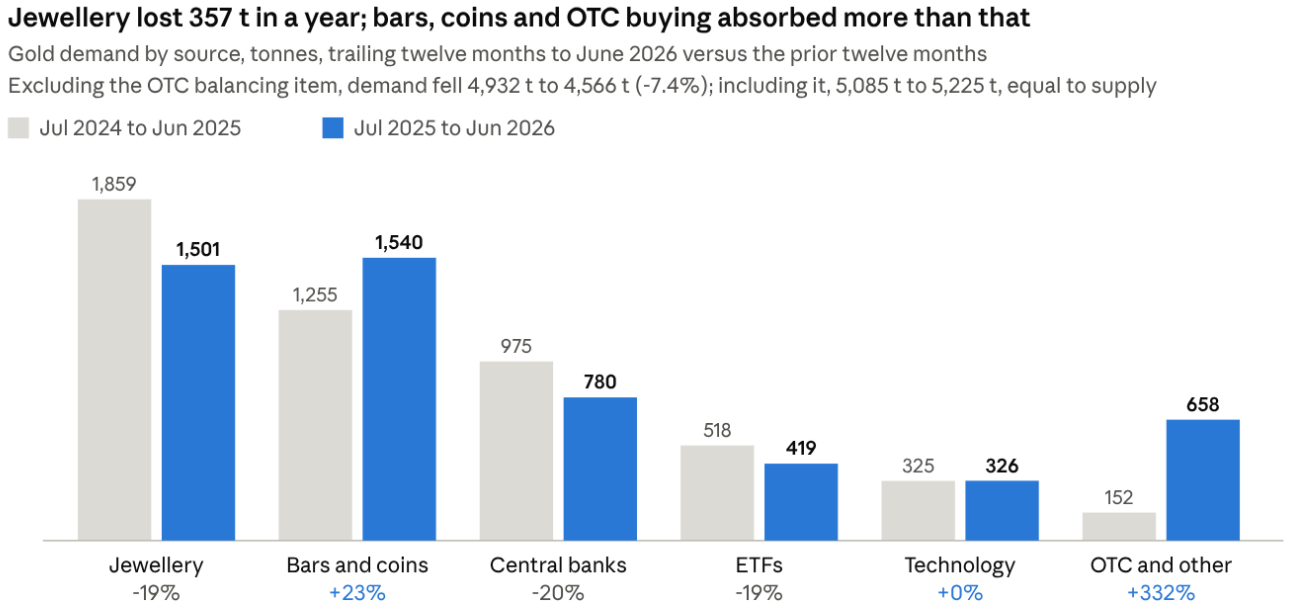
Source: ZION panel (gold, Industrial Production, US CPI) 1990 to 2026; regime pool = months sharing the current type under the recursion's owning cell; spot = COMEX GC=F close 26 Oct 2026.

The chart is one object, not five. Every horizon is read off the same 309 historical months whose macro type matches October 2026 under the owning cell's ratio, so the bands widen with time the way a single distribution should, and no horizon can contradict another. Two features matter for positioning. The median path rises steadily but the 25th percentile stays within $90 of spot for nine months, so the base case is a grind higher with a flat floor, not a breakout. And the upside tail opens much faster than the downside: by twelve months the 90th percentile is $1,806 above spot while the 10th is $301 below. That asymmetry, not the median, is the reason to hold the position through the 17% correction already underway. The dashed line shows what an investor who ignored the regime would expect: a median of $4,247 at a year, and a probability of a higher price that plateaus at 62%.

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The five markets of gold



Source: World Gold Council, Gold Demand Trends Q2 2026 tables (quarterly series, 2010 to Q2 2026), downloaded 19 Oct 2026; trailing twelve months summed from the quarterly rows.

Demand has rotated, not collapsed. Total demand over the twelve months to June 2026 was 4,566 t, 7% below the prior year, while supply rose 3% to a record 5,225 t (mine output 3,882 t, recycling 1,408 t). The gap is the OTC line, which the World Gold Council uses as the balancing item for institutional and high-net-worth bar buying that no other series captures. The price did the rationing: the LBMA average for Q2 2026 was $4,506/oz, 37% above a year earlier.

Central banks. Official buying including the Council's estimate of unreported purchases was 289 t in Q2 2026, 62% above Q2 2025, after a weak second half of 2025; the trailing year is 780 t, down from 975 t. Reported purchases alone, from the IMF reserve template that 89 countries file, were just 104 t in the six months to August and 190 t year to date, so roughly two-thirds of official demand is now unreported, which is the China-and-Gulf pattern of the last three years. Our own study found that reported flows are largely explained by inflation, money supply and oil, so we read the official bid as reinforcing the macro regime rather than as an independent signal.

Investment: ETFs. Physically backed ETFs sold 45 t in Q2 as the price corrected, then bought 211 t in the three months to September, taking global holdings to a record 4,256 t at end-September. Year-to-date inflow is 226 t against 803 t in 2025. Western investment demand is therefore positive but no longer the marginal buyer it was in 2025.

Investment: bars and coins. Retail bullion is the strongest market: 1,540 t over twelve months, up 23%, led by mainland China (507 t, up 32%) and India (300 t, up 22%), with Turkey up 13%. Physical premiums confirm it. Shanghai traded $17.92/oz over London in October, the 91st percentile of the series since 2003 and against a $3.96 median; India flipped from a deep discount in the summer to a $5.48 premium, the 77th percentile.

Jewellery. The casualty of the price. Fabrication fell 19% over twelve months to 1,501 t, with India down 23% to 412 t, China down 25% to 302 t, the US down 23% and the Middle East down 19%. The 2010 to 2019 run rate was

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about 2,290 t a year. This is the single largest negative in the demand picture and it is price-elastic: a sustained correction would bring part of it back and cushion the downside.

Technology. Flat at 326 t, in line with the prior year and 12% below its 2010s average, as electronics thrifting offsets AI-related substrate demand. It neither helps nor hurts the view.

Supply. Mine production reached a record 966 t in Q2 and 3,882 t over the year, up 3%, with producer de-hedging a further 65 t of demand. Recycling rose only 2% despite the price, which suggests households are holding rather than selling. Supply growth of 3% a year is not a constraint on price at these levels, but it is not a support either.

Positioning, macro backdrop and the ZOLTAR Equity Model

Positioning is the crowded part of the trade. COMEX non-commercial net length was 210,335 contracts at the start of October, 53% of open interest. That is the 99th percentile of the series since 1986 and the 90th percentile of the last five years, and it rose by ten points of open interest over the summer even as the price corrected. Our walk-forward test of positioning as a predictor found a small positive edge (three points over drift at a three-month lag) and nothing admissible, so we do not trade on it. We do size on it: a long this crowded is why we prefer to add on weakness rather than at the market.

Rates and the dollar explain the correction, not a change of regime. Gold is down 17% over six months from the spring high and up 3% year on year. Over the same six months the 10-year yield rose 87 bp to 5.19%, the 2-year rose 94 bp to 4.65%, and the dollar index firmed 1.4% to 99.0. Against that, CPI inflation is running at 4.1%, so the real 10-year yield is 1.1%, oil is $102 (up 65% on the year), and M2 is growing 5.7%. A positive but low real yield with inflation above 4% is the macro state in which gold has historically ground higher rather than broken; it is the state the owning cell is detecting.

Indicator	Latest	6-month change	Read for gold
10-year Treasury	5.19%	+87 bp	headwind
2-year Treasury	4.65%	+94 bp	headwind
Fed funds	3.75%	+11 bp	neutral
Real 10-year (10y less CPI)	1.09%	higher	mild headwind
CPI, year on year	4.1%	+1.5 pts (6m)	tailwind
Dollar index	99.0	+1.4%	mild headwind
WTI crude	$102	+2% (6m), +65% (12m)	tailwind via inflation
S&P 500	7,750	+11.4%	competing asset
VIX	19.4	–5 pts	neutral

The ZOLTAR Equity Model, our S&P 500 six-month call, is standing aside. It issues an UP call on the S&P only when six-month CAPE momentum is positive and the six-month CPI change is at or below its historical median. For October 2026 the momentum spine is UP (CAPE momentum +7.4%, CAPE 41.8) but the inflation gate is CLOSED: six-month CPI change is 2.0% against a 1.5% median. The call is ABSTAIN, resolving 1 April 2027. The rule has no fitted parameters; since 1957 it has issued 282 UP calls at 84% accuracy against a 70% base rate (lower bound on overlap-deflated count .72), and since 1990, 214 calls at 86% against 76%.

For gold the ZOLTAR Equity Model's abstention matters in two ways. The inflation state that closes the ZOLTAR Equity Model's gate is the same state that supports the gold regime, so the two models are reading one macro fact from two sides rather than disagreeing. And in the integrated monthly book the equity sleeve is held only on a

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ZOLTAR Equity Model UP call while the gold sleeve is held on the recursion call, so the book is currently long gold and not long the S&P on these two systems. The house equity position therefore adds no competing claim on capital over the next six months, and the gold view does not depend on equities falling.

Seasonal tilt is a lean, not a signal. The current weakness is concentrated in price-elastic jewellery demand, down 19% year on year — the one market the November-to-March Indian and Chinese physical-buying season directly addresses. Gold's own history shows a mild positive tilt into that window: since 1968 a November entry has averaged about +1.4% above the pooled six-month return, nearer +2% in the 2000s. But that entry ranks only third of the twelve calendar months and is not statistically distinguishable from zero on its own, so we treat it as a lean, not a signal. For an investor who wants to express it, the cleanest vehicle is a small, defined-risk at- or slightly-out-of-the-money six-month GLD call held through the season — the long-call expression, and the opposite of selling the upside call in the strangle in the hedging section below.

Scenarios

The three scenarios are the quartiles of the same distribution that draws the fan chart, so their probabilities and ranges tie to the horizon table by construction. Bull is the top quarter of regime-matched outcomes, bear the bottom quarter, base the middle half.

Scenario	Probability	6-month range	12-month range	What has to happen
Bull	25%	$4,613 to $4,997 (90th pct) and above	$5,158 to $5,840 (90th pct) and above	Yields peak and the dollar rolls over; central bank buying returns to the 2024 to 2025 pace of 1,000 t a year; ETF inflows resume at the 2025 rate; Asian premiums stay elevated. Jewellery stays weak and does not matter.
Base	50%	$3,948 to $4,613, median $4,259	$4,051 to $5,158, median $4,448	Yields plateau near 5.2%; CPI holds near 4%; official and retail Asian buying continue at the current pace; ETF flows modestly positive; speculative length drifts lower without a forced unwind. Gold grinds higher at the regime's historical rate.
Bear	25%	$3,693 (10th pct) to $3,948	$3,733 (10th pct) to $4,051	A further 50 to 100 bp rise in real yields, or a dollar rally above 103; the 53%-of-open-interest speculative long unwinds; central banks pause as they did in the second half of 2025. The jewellery market, 19% below last year, is the floor: a sustained price below $4,000 brings part of the 357 t of lost fabrication back.

Two observations on the shape. The bear range at twelve months is almost the same as at six, $3,733 against $3,693, because the regime's historical downside has been a correction that does not deepen with time, whereas the bull range keeps widening. And the median path does not regain the 2026 spring high of about $4,815 within twelve months; only the 75th percentile crosses it, between six and nine months out. We would not underwrite new highs on a six-month view.

Key risks

Downside risks to the view

- **A crowded long unwinds.** Speculative net length at 53% of open interest is the 99th percentile since 1986. In past episodes at or near this level the first leg of an unwind has been fast and has not needed a macro trigger. Our bear band ($3,690 to $3,950 over six months) assumes an orderly one.

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- **Real yields keep rising.** The 10-year has risen 87 bp in six months. Another 50 to 100 bp with inflation flat would take the real yield toward 2%, a level at which the regime the owning cell detects has historically ended.
- **Jewellery does not come back.** Fabrication is down 19% and the price elasticity we rely on for the floor was measured in a world of $1,300 to $2,000 gold. At $4,000 the substitution to lighter pieces and 18-carat may be structural.
- **Official buying pauses again.** The second half of 2025 showed central banks will step back when the price runs; trailing-year official demand is already down 20%.
- **Regime dependence of the model.** The cell's 82% record is entirely UP calls in bull regimes. If the regime has already turned, the model will be the last to know; its forward ledger has one unresolved row.

Upside risks

- **Dollar reserve diversification accelerates.** Two-thirds of official buying is now unreported; a step up in that channel would not show in any series until after the fact.
- **Western investors are under-allocated.** ETF holdings are at a record in tonnes but year-to-date inflow is a quarter of 2025's. A rates peak would reopen that channel on top of Asian physical demand that is already at 91st-percentile premiums.
- **Supply response is absent.** Mine output grows 3% a year and recycling has not responded to a 37% price rise. There is no supply valve at these prices.
- **Inflation stays above 4%.** The condition that closes the ZOLTAR Equity Model's gate is the condition that extends gold's regime.

Hedging the position

We would hedge the tail, not the view, and the timing is favourable because gold options are priced well below realized volatility. Six-month at-the-money implied volatility on GLD is about 11%, against 17% realized over the past month and 22% over three months. Buying protection this far below realized is the cheap-volatility condition our options desk flags, so the cost of insurance is unusually low right now.

The risk worth hedging is the crowded-long unwind, not a change in the macro regime. Regime history says the downside is a sharp but shallow move: the bear band is $3,690 to $3,950 at six months and barely deepens by twelve. That is a drawdown to insure against, not a trend to position for.

Hedging Strategy with Options

Simplest: a quartile strangle around the fan. The most direct structure is to sell the fan's own quartiles — a twelve-month strangle that sells the $5,158 call (75th percentile) and the $4,051 put (25th percentile), the two edges of the twelve-month interquartile band shown in the key statistics above. The regime pool puts a 50% chance on gold finishing inside that band at twelve months, 25% above and 25% below, so the structure monetizes the base-case grind: in the modal outcome both legs expire worthless and the position keeps the net premium, and assignment happens only where a holder would act anyway — trimming into the top quartile near $5,158, adding in the bottom quartile near $4,051. It collects premium rather than paying it, which makes it an income-and-discipline overlay, not a hedge.

Two cautions make it a sleeve tool rather than the default. First, it runs against the core view: selling the 75th-percentile call caps participation above $5,158, and this note argues the upside tail is several times the downside — the twelve-month 90th percentile sits near $5,840 — so the strangle trades that convex tail for premium. Second, because the twelve-month fan is strongly skewed up, the 25th-percentile put strike of $4,051 is essentially at-the-money, barely above the $4,035 spot, so the credit is large (about 11% of notional on current GLD pricing) but

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downside assignment is likely, roughly one time in four, which in practice means buying more gold at about today's price. We would run it only on a core sleeve held for income and content to rebalance mechanically, never on the tactical position added into strength. The desk prices the exact net credit before execution.

Recommended: a six-month GLD put spread. Buying a 5% out-of-the-money put and selling a 10% out-of-the-money put costs about 1.3% of notional and covers roughly $3,835 down to $3,630 an ounce, the 10th-to-25th-percentile zone where the bear case sits. An outright 5% put costs about 2.9%. We prefer the spread because the thesis is that the upside tail is larger than the downside, and the put spread caps the cost of the bad scenario without capping the good one.

We would not default to a collar. A collar (buy the 5% put, sell a 5% call) is currently a net credit of about 1.4%, because the market is pricing upside calls richer than downside puts. That richness is the options market agreeing with our upside-skew thesis and charging for it. Selling that call harvests the premium but gives away exactly the tail we are long; the credit is the tell, not the reason. Use a collar only for a mandate that cannot carry the bear band.

Hedge (6-month unless noted, on GLD)	Cost, % of notional	Protects	Caps upside
Short strangle (12-mo): sell $4,051 put + $5,158 call (the quartiles)	~11% credit*	none — income / rebalance	yes, above ~$5,158/oz
Outright 5% OTM put	~2.9%	below ~$3,835/oz	no
5% / 10% OTM put spread (recommended)	~1.3%	$3,835 to $3,630/oz	no
Collar: buy 5% put, sell 5% call	~1.4% credit	below ~$3,835/oz	yes, above ~$4,237/oz
No option hedge; size by adding on weakness	0	nothing	no

The put leg at the 25th percentile is near-the-money on the upside-skewed twelve-month fan, so the net credit is large (~11%) but downside assignment runs about one in four; the options desk prices the exact figure.

Hedge the tactical sleeve, not the core. For a drift-grade Overweight we would carry the put spread only on the portion added into strength, and leave the core position to ride. On weakness toward the 25th percentile we would add unhedged, since that is where the risk and reward improve. At the book level the position is already partly offset: the integrated book holds a long-dollar sleeve and a two-year Treasury hedge, which lean against the two macro drivers of a gold selloff, and gold itself is the book's designated crisis hedge. The put spread addresses the one risk those offsets do not, a positioning-driven unwind specific to gold.

A tactical options edge: the December-to-February seasonal

Separate from the core view and from the tail hedge above, our seasonal work this month surfaced one opportunistic edge worth flagging for the next twelve months. It is a lean, not a thesis, and we size it as one.

The pattern. Gold's strongest three-month stretch, measured over 1968 to 2026, is **December through February** — not the Diwali period, which is a coin flip, but the later window of Chinese New Year and the peak Indian wedding season. On a sequential, no-parameters test the December-start window ranks first of all twelve three-month windows, averaging +5.4% with a 64% hit rate, and it is positive in every era: +8.0% in 1968–1989, +4.1% in 1990–2009, +3.4% in 2010–2026.

Why it is a lean, not a signal. The edge over the all-window base is +2.9 points, but a year-level bootstrap puts the 95% confidence interval at –0.5% to +6.8%: it is the single best window and clears a 95% one-sided bar, yet the two-sided interval still touches zero. We also tested whether the effect is a reversal of the jewellery weakness described earlier, and it is not — the December-to-February strength appears whether or not jewellery demand was

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down that year, so it is general seasonality rather than a demand-reversal story. As a standalone long it has returned about 4.6% a year while invested only a quarter of the time (Sortino 1.31), with a worst historical window of –19%.

How we would express it. This is an opportunistic long, not protection, so it is defined-risk and time-boxed:

- **Enter in early December and exit by the end of February.** The edge evaporates in March, so the exit is a hard time-stop, not a view to hold.
- **Buy a slightly in-the-money (about 0.6-delta) GLD call at an April expiry**, one tenor past the exit. It is a directional drift of a few per cent, not a tail bet, so we want delta rather than cheap convexity; an April expiry keeps time value in the option through the February exit and avoids rolling mid-window.
- **Check dealer gamma first.** When GLD dealers are short gamma, or spot sits below the gamma flip, an up-move is amplified and the drift has more room, so we would size up; when positioning is long-gamma and pinned, we would size down or move the strike further in-the-money.
- **Size it small.** The defined risk is the premium; the lean deserves a tilt, not a position.

We run this independently of the core Overweight and the put-spread hedge. It neither protects the core nor expresses the twelve-month view — it simply harvests a measured calendar tendency with a known entry, a known expiry, and a known exit.

Methodology and model record

How the projections are built. The monthly ZION panel (gold, macro and rates series, 1990 to October 2026) is partitioned by a sign grammar on an anchor ratio and its two legs. The ZION recursion selects, each month and using only months already resolved, the cells whose trailing record clears a lower-bound test; the cell owning October 2026 is Industrial Production over CPI, 12-month change, type 14. The projection pool is every past month that shares that type under the same ratio, 303 to 309 months depending on horizon. Forward returns at 1, 3, 6, 9 and 12 months are taken from that one pool, and the percentiles are applied to the 26 October COMEX close. Because all five horizons use the same months, the fan is internally consistent and cannot produce a 3-month range outside its 6-month range. The unconditional reference uses all months since 1990.

What the systems have demonstrated. The recursion has acted on 102 of 430 months since 1990 with a 74.5% hit rate, 7.8 points above the up-rate of the months it acted on, lower bound on overlap-deflated count .51. The owning cell is 82% on 91 calls, all UP; it is a bull-regime detector and we present its confidence as moderate for that reason. The step-1 cell (254 months, 66.5%, +7 points) is abstaining this month. The neuron-and-rules assessment stack that previously reported 84.7% at high confidence failed nested discovery in October 2026 and is carried as a candidate only; nothing in this report uses it. The rolling one- and three-month readings are abstaining because no six-month cell call is live from the last five months.

What they have not demonstrated. No system in the house has shown timing skill in gold at any horizon under honest scoring; the edge is regime identification plus drift. Three orthogonality studies this month (Indian equities, speculative positioning, ETF and reported central bank flows) found no admissible independent predictor; positioning is orthogonal with a three-point edge, and reported official flows are explained by inflation, money and oil. Physical premiums and the five-market demand data were obtained in October 2026 and have not yet been tested as predictors; they are used here as descriptive context only.

ZOLTAR Equity Model. S&P 500 six-month call: UP when six-month CAPE momentum is positive and six-month CPI change is at or below its expanding median, otherwise ABSTAIN; no fitted parameters; sequential record from 1957. Current call ABSTAIN (gate closed), resolving 1 April 2027.

Data sources. ZION macro panel (Shiller, FRED, Yahoo); World Gold Council Gold Demand Trends Q2 2026 tables, ETF holdings and flows by fund (monthly, 2003 to September 2026), central bank monthly changes (2002 to August

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2026), Shanghai and India premiums (daily, averaged monthly); IMF International Reserves template, official gold volume, 89 countries; CFTC Commitments of Traders, COMEX gold, futures only, 1986 to October 2026; SPDR Gold Trust historical archive and GLD option chain (26 October 2026); COMEX front-month settlement via Yahoo Finance. All retrieved 14 to 26 October 2026.

Important disclosures and limitations

This report is an internal research product of the ZION and ZION_CHAIN desks and is not investment advice, an offer, or a solicitation. It is prepared for the operator's own decision-making and has not been reviewed by any regulator or compliance function.

Model limitations. The price ranges are empirical percentiles of historical forward returns in months that resemble the current macro regime; they are not forecasts of a specific path and they assume the next twelve months are drawn from the same distribution as 1990 to 2026. The owning cell's record consists entirely of UP calls made in rising markets, so its confidence is a statement about the regime, not about timing. The six-month horizon is the only one on which the house systems issue calls and keep an as-issued ledger; the 1, 3, 9 and 12-month ranges are read off the same analogue pool and have no separate forward record. Under the house admission rule the current call is a candidate on the forward tape, with one unresolved row, not a validated edge.

Data limitations. World Gold Council quarterly data begin in 2010 and the latest quarter is Q2 2026; central bank figures include the Council's estimate of unreported purchases, which is revised. The IMF reserve template covers reporting countries only. Physical premiums are monthly averages of daily series and the India series has gaps. CFTC positioning is futures-only, legacy format. The COMEX close used as spot is the front-month settlement on 26 October 2026, which differs from the London fix. The GLD implied-volatility and option-structure costs are read from the 26 October 2026 chain and are indicative; the desk prices exact levels at execution.

Known defects corrected before this report. A one-month look-ahead in an earlier gold sandbox P&L and a same-week throttle leak in the weekly book backtest were identified and documented on 14 and 19 October 2026; neither affects the figures here, which use returns from the month after issue only.

Conflicts. The integrated monthly book holds a gold sleeve on the recursion call described in this report, and a 7.5% gold ballast in the weekly book. The desk therefore has a position consistent with the view expressed.

All figures as of 26 October 2026 unless stated. Prices in US dollars per troy ounce. Tonnes are metric.

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